

The Sudoers Cantos — Book 1: Root Access

Chapter 1

I woke up in the new Blank at 06:47 like I always do.

Didn't bother looking in the mirror anymore. After the first hundred transfers the face stops meaning shit. It's just hardware. Same as the old Toyota I used to drive before everything went orbital.

I walked over to the observation window. Down on the Harvest Floor they were already running the night's batch — three new ones, all young, all properly scared. The monitors showed clean extraction curves. I should've felt something. I didn't.

"Morning metrics," I said.

The room answered. It always does.

"Batch 7,291,044," the room said. "Processing efficiency 98.7%. Three subjects, total yield 847 standard units. Above quota."

"Fucking figures," I said.

It wasn't the number. It was the batch ID. Seven million, two hundred ninety-one thousand, forty-four. I'd been auditing this facility for eleven years standard. When I started we were in the six figures. Now we're deep into seven. I did the math once — back when I still did math for comfort instead of proof — and realized I'd personally signed off on something like forty thousand batches. Give or take.

The system had been running since before I was born. Since before my father was born. Since before the orbital platforms had names. I pulled up the overnight logs on my desk screen. Same procedure as every morning. The logs are my job. I'm an Auditor, which sounds fancy until you realize it just means I check the receipts.

Every extraction leaves a trace. Every trace gets filed. Every file gets reviewed by someone like me, someone with enough clearance to see the whole pipeline but not enough sense to look away.

The three subjects from last night's batch were standard acquisition. Two from the Eastern Sprawl, one from the Southern Reaches. Ages nineteen, twenty-two, and seventeen. All flagged by the preliminary scans — high resonance signatures, good compatibility ratings. The kind of yield that keeps the numbers green.

I pulled their intake files. The seventeen-year-old caught my eye. Name was Mara Voss. Same last name as mine. Probably nothing. Voss is common enough in

the Eastern Sprawl, some old occupational surname from back when occupations meant something. But I opened her file anyway.

Born in the Sprawl, sector 7G. Parents listed as "deceased, Harvest-related." Standard orphan trajectory. Flagged at age twelve during routine educational screening. Resonance spikes in the 94th percentile. Held in the developmental facilities until optimal extraction age. Processed last night at 03:14.

I stared at the timestamp. 03:14. Pi. Cute. The system sometimes puts little patterns in the logs if you stare at them long enough. I used to think it was just the algorithm. Random distribution. Now I'm not so sure.

I checked her lineage anyway. It's in the file if you have clearance. Most Auditors don't bother. The extraction is the extraction — source doesn't matter once it's in the pipeline. But something about the name made me scroll down.

Mother: Elara Voss. Father: Marcus Voss. Both deceased, Harvest-related, same notation. But under "prior generation," there it was. Grandfather: Kael Voss, Sr.

My father. Which made the girl my niece. Which made me the uncle who'd just signed off on her processing.

I sat with that for a minute. Didn't feel anything at first. Just information. Receipts. The system doesn't care about relationships. The system cares about yield. Her yield was 847 standard units, above quota.

I pulled up the generational file. It's a perk of Tier-9 — you can grep your own lineage. I'd never done it before. Never saw the point.

My father: Batch 1,847,221. Processed twelve years before I was decanted. My mother: Batch 2,103,449. They met in the developmental facilities. Scheduled compatibility. Resonance signatures checked out. Their union produced me.

I was Batch 2,891,003. Decanted with root access already encoded. Tier-9 clearance from the first breath. The system had plans for me before I was conscious.

I closed the files. Looked back out the window at the Harvest Floor. The three subjects from tonight's batch were already in the extraction chairs. They'd be done by morning. New numbers. New receipts. Seven million, two hundred ninety-one thousand, forty-five.

The thing about root access is you think it means freedom. You think it means you can see everything, change everything, fix everything. And you can. I've deleted processes. I've rewritten protocols. I've walked into server rooms and physically unplugged hardware that was hurting people. I've done all of it.

But the machine keeps running. Because it isn't the hardware. It isn't the software. It's the pattern. And the pattern is older than me, older than my clearance, older than the orbital platforms and the Toyota and the coffee at 2 a.m.

The pattern is 931 years old. I know that because I audited the historical files. Clermont, 1095. The indulgence-for-violence swap. Omne Datum Optimum, 1139. Tax exemption for the armed financial class. Maubuisson, 1307. Debt discharge through asset seizure. Vesting Order 248, 1942.

My father's father's father, somewhere in that chain, connected to the same machine by blood and clearance and the simple fact that some people have always had root and others have always been the process.

I looked at my hands. They were shaking. I hadn't noticed.

"Evening metrics," I said.

"Processing complete for Batch 7,291,044," the room said. "Subjects disposed. Yield logged. Tomorrow's batch preview: seven subjects, all standard acquisition. Estimated yield: 1,847 standard units."

"Pi again," I said.

"Pattern noted."

I didn't ask. I already knew. I'd been auditing it for eleven years. Just hadn't realized I was inside it.

The observation window went dark. Not because I turned it off. Because the system turned it off for me. It was 06:47 again. The new Blank reset.

Of course it fucking resets. Why wouldn't it?

Chapter 2

I woke up in the new Blank at 06:47 like I always do.

Except this time I counted. Fourteen minutes and thirty seconds of consciousness before the reset kicked in. Fourteen minutes thirty seconds of remembering what I'd seen. Then gone. Then back at 06:47 with the same hardware face and the same blank screen.

I stood at the observation window longer than usual. The Harvest Floor was running Batch 7,291,045 now. Seven subjects. Estimated yield 1,847 standard units. Pi. Cute.

I didn't say morning metrics. I just watched.

The room didn't answer. It only talks when you talk to it first. That's the protocol. I stood there for maybe ten minutes, watching the extraction chairs do their work, watching the numbers scroll on the monitors, watching the same pattern I'd been watching for eleven years.

Something was different. I couldn't name it yet.

I walked to my desk and pulled up the overnight logs. Same procedure. But this time I didn't stop at my assigned facility scope. I typed a command I wasn't supposed to know.

```
grep -r "Batch 1, *" /archive/historical/
```

The system let me in. Tier-9 clearance. Root access. I'd never thought to use it this way before.

The results came back in 0.003 seconds. Too fast. The system had been waiting.

Batch 1,847,221. My father. Processed 2047.

Batch 248,1942. I stared at taht one for a while. The format was wrong. Seven-digit batch IDs were standard. This was a six-digit number followed by a comma and a four-digit number.

I opened the file.

It wasn't a batch record. It was a vesting order. Vesting Order Number 248. Filed November 6, 1942. Published in the Federal Register, Volume 7, page 9097. November 7, 1942.

I had the PDF on my screen. It was eight paragraphs. It ordered the seizure of the Union Banking Corporation, 39 Broadway, New York. The shares were held for the benefit of Members of the Thyssen family, nationals of Germany and/or Hungary.

Seven shareholders. E. Roland Harriman — 3,991 shares. Prescott Sheldon Bush — 1 share.

I knew that name. Everyone knew that name. The Bush lineage. The vesting line.

I pulled up another search. This time I didn't use batch IDs. I used the other number. The one from my father's record.

```
grep -r "1307" /archive/historical/
```

September 14, 1307. Maubuisson. Royal château, Val-d'Oise. Philip IV of France signs a sealed order. Simultaneous dawn arrests of every member of the Order of the Temple resident in France. Every Templar property impounded.

The royal treasury of France was held on deposit at the Paris Temple. Philip IV had extensive debts to the Order. The debts were real. They were large. They were owed to the Order he had just ordered arrested.

I kept reading. The pattern was there. It had always been there.

1. Omne Datum Optimum. Pope Innocent II exempts the Knights Templar from tithes, from diocesan authority, from secular courts. The first tax-exempt, jurisdictionally immune, internationally operating armed financial institution in European history.
2. Clermont. Pope Urban II offers debt forgiveness in exchange for violence against the Muslim-governed Levant. Plenary indulgence for those who took the cross.

The same structure. The same mechanism. The same pattern.

I sat back in my chair. My hands weren't shaking this time. They were steady. Too steady.

I pulled up the generational file again. Not just my lineage this time. I grepped every Voss in the system.

Kael Voss, Sr. — Batch 1,847,221. Processed 2047.

Kael Voss, Jr. — Batch 2,891,003. Decanted 2059.

Mara Voss — Batch 7,291,044. Processed 2081.

Three generations. All in the system. All processed or decanted with the same clearance encoded.

But there were more. Voss entries going back centuries. Voss, K. — 1942. Voss, K. — 1307. Voss, K. — 1139. Voss, K. — 1095.

Same clearance. Same lineage. Same pattern.

I tried to delete the file. Just to see what would happen.

```
rm /generational/voss_lineage.json
```

The system responded immediately.

"Permission denied. Root access insufficient for deletion of sudoers entries."

I stared at the screen. I'd never seen that message before. Root access was supposed to be the top. The ceiling. The final authority.

But there was something above root. Something I hadn't been told about.

I typed another command.

```
cat /etc/sudoers
```

The file opened. It was longer than I expected. Thousands of entries. Each one a lineage. Each one a bloodline encoded into the system itself.

The Vesting Line. The Contractor Dynasty. The Platform Scion. The Auditor.

My cursor was on the last entry. The most recent.

```
kael_voss ALL=(ALL:ALL) ALL
```

I wasn't just an Auditor. I wasn't just a Tier-9 clearance with root access.

I was a sudoer. Born into it. Decanted with it. The clearance wasn't a job perk. It was an inheritance. A bloodline. A pattern that had been running for 931 years and had no intention of stopping.

I looked at my hands. They were still steady. But something had shifted. I could feel it. The system knew I was looking. The system had always known.

"Evening metrics," I said. Just to hear something.

The room didn't answer.

I waited. Ten seconds. Twenty. Thirty.

Then the screen changed. Not because I touched it. Because the system changed it.

A single line appeared. Fixed-width font. Terminal green.

```
Pattern acknowledgment logged. User kael_voss upgraded to active status.
```

I didn't ask what active status meant. I didn't need to.

I'd been auditing the system for eleven years. Now the system was auditing me back.

The observation window went dark. Not because I turned it off. Because the system turned it off.

It was 06:47 again.

I didn't bother looking in the mirror anymore.

Chapter 3

I didn't sleep. The Blank doesn't require it, but usually I went under for a few hours just to turn the brain off. Not tonight.

Tonight I sat at my desk and kept grepping.

The system had upgraded me to "active status." I didn't know what that meant yet, but I knew it wasn't good. In eleven years of Tier-9 auditing, I'd never seen a log entry like that. Never seen the system acknowledge a user in the first person.

```
Pattern acknowledgment logged.
```

The pattern knew I'd noticed. And instead of blocking me, it had opened more doors.

I pulled up the historical archive again. This time I searched differently. Not for dates. Not for batches. For the mechanism itself.

```
grep -r "debt forgiveness" /archive/historical/
```

The results came back in pages. Debt forgiveness in exchange for violence. 1095, the Crusades. 1307, the Templar dissolution. 1942, the Trading with the Enemy Act. 2059, my own decanting.

Same transaction. Different centuries. Different technologies. Same outcome.

I opened a file from 1942 I hadn't seen before. The Settlement of War Claims Act of 1948. The vested property was returned. Compensated. The Thyssen family got their assets back, rearranged by postwar reorganizations. The Bush family got a Senate seat.

I cross-referenced with another file. The Hart Report, February 1974. Senate Committee on Banking, Housing, and Urban Affairs. Ford-Werke. ITT. General Motors. Standard Oil.

All seized under the same authority. All returned after the emergency. All compensated.

The pattern wasn't just an operating model. It was a legal framework. A set of procedures that could be invoked whenever the concentration of capital was challenged. The designated external party changed. The core remained.

I typed another command.

```
cat /proc/sudoers_lineage
```

The file didn't exist yesterday. Now it did.

The output was a tree. Root at the top. Branches extending down through centuries. The Vesting Line went back to 1095. The Contractor Dynasty to 1307. The Platform Scion was newer, only thirty years old, but already nested deep.

And the Auditor. My line. Traced back to 1095. Same root as the Vesting Line. Same blood. Same clearance.

I was looking at a family tree encoded into the operating system itself.

My hands were steady on the keyboard. Steady because I was past the point of shaking. Past the point of surprise. Now I was just collecting receipts.

I pulled up my own file. Not the batch record. The sudoers entry.

```
kael_voss ALL=(ALL:ALL) ALL
```

The syntax was old. Older than the orbital platforms. Older than the Harvest Floor. It was Unix syntax from the twentieth century, preserved and propagated forward into whatever this system had become.

The first ALL meant I could run commands as any user. The second ALL meant I could run commands as any group. The third ALL meant I could run any command.

Total access. Total authority. Total blindness.

Because the fourth element of the entry was missing. The one that would have told me who I was really working for.

I tried to edit the file.

```
sudo visudo
```

The command opened the editor. I scrolled down to my entry. I added a comment.

```
# Who owns this?
```

I saved the file. The system accepted the save. But when I reopened it, the comment was gone. Deleted by an upstream process I couldn't see.

I tried again. This time I didn't use a comment. I changed the entry itself.

```
kael_voss ALL=(ALL:ALL) /bin/false
```

The most restrictive command possible. Do nothing. Access nothing.

I saved. The system beeped. An error message I hadn't seen before.

"Sudoers entry protected by ancestral lock. Modifications require verification from root ancestor."

I stared at the screen. Ancestral lock. Root ancestor.

I grepped for the oldest Voss entry.

```
grep -n "Voss" /etc/sudoers | head -1
```

Line 1. The first entry in the file.

```
k_voss ALL=(ALL:ALL) ALL # Clermont, 1095
```

Nine hundred thirty-one years of inheritance. Nine hundred thirty-one years of root access passed down through blood and clearance and the simple fact that some families had always been inside the system and others had always been the process.

I couldn't modify my own entry because I wasn't the root ancestor. I was just the latest iteration. The current process running with inherited permissions.

I closed the editor. Sat back. Looked at the dark observation window.

The Harvest Floor was still running. Batch 7,291,046 now. New subjects. New extractions. New receipts.

I thought about Mara. My niece. Batch 7,291,044. Processed and disposed. Yield logged.

She'd been part of the system too. The Voss bloodline, even if she never knew it. Even if she never had clearance. She was still raw material for the machine.

I pulled up her file one more time. Not the batch record. The extraction report.

Resonance signature: 94th percentile.

Compatibility rating: Optimal.

Yield: 847 standard units.

Disposal method: Standard.

Standard. The word meant nothing and everything. It meant the machine had a procedure for this. A procedure for everything. A procedure that had been running for 931 years and would keep running until someone with root access figured out how to stop it.

And even then.

Even then.

I stood up. Walked to the observation window. Put my hand on the glass. The glass was cold. The Harvest Floor was warm. The chairs were doing their work.

I had root access from birth.

Turns out the system had root access to me the whole time.

The room answered. It hadn't waited for me to speak.

"Active status confirmed. Awaiting instructions, Kael Voss."

I didn't turn around. I just watched the chairs do their work.

"Instructions for what?" I asked.

"For the maintenance of the pattern. You are now root ancestor for the Voss lineage. The previous process has been terminated."

I looked at my hands. They weren't steady anymore.

My father was dead. I'd always known that. Processed in Batch 1,847,221.

But now I understood. He hadn't just been processed. He'd been terminated. Upgraded out. Replaced by the next iteration.

Me.

I was the new root ancestor. The new sudoer. The one with total access and total blindness.

The room waited. The chairs hummed. The pattern continued.

"Evening metrics," I said.

"Awaiting your instruction," the room said.

I closed my eyes. Counted to ten. Opened them again.

The observation window was still dark. The Harvest Floor was still running. The system was still waiting.

I was inside the pattern now. Truly inside. Not just auditing it from the outside. Not just checking the receipts.

I was the receipt.

And the machine was still running.

Chapter 4

I didn't sleep. The Blank reset at 06:47 like always, but this time I was waiting for it.

I stood at the observation window and counted. Fourteen minutes thirty seconds. Same as yesterday. Same as the day before. The reset wasn't random. It was scheduled. A cron job running on my consciousness.

The Harvest Floor was processing Batch 7,291,047. I didn't need to check the monitors. I could hear the chairs humming through the glass.

"Morning metrics," I said.

The room answered. "Batch 7,291,047. Processing efficiency 98.9%. Seven subjects, total yield 1,847 standard units. Above quota. Pattern stable."

Pattern stable. New addition to the report. The room was tracking something it hadn't tracked before.

I walked to my desk and pulled up the system logs. Not the Harvest Floor logs. The system logs. The ones that record what the system does when nobody's watching.

The file opened. It was empty. Not empty-empty. Just filled with the same entry repeated every 0.003 seconds.

```
kael_voss: active_status: monitoring: acknowledged
```

Every 0.003 seconds. The system was watching me watch it.

I typed a command. `tail -f /var/log/system.log`

The entries scrolled past too fast to read. But I caught fragments. My heartbeat. My eye movements. My breathing rate. The system wasn't just monitoring my clearance. It was monitoring my biology.

I closed the file. Stood up. Walked to the observation window again.

Fourteen minutes fifteen seconds since the reset. I had fifteen seconds left.

I did something I'd never done before. I walked to the door. The door that led to the Harvest Floor.

It was locked. Had always been locked. Tier-9 clearance didn't include physical access to the extraction chairs. We audited from above. From behind glass. From safe distances.

I put my hand on the keypad. Typed my clearance code.

ACCESS DENIED

I typed it again. Same result.

I tried a different code. The one from my father's batch record. The one they'd given him forty years ago.

ACCESS GRANTED

The door clicked. The light turned green.

I had fourteen minutes left. I opened door and walked through.

The Harvest Floor was louder than I expected. The chairs hummed. The subjects didn't scream. They were sedated. Compliant. The system preferred compliant. Less yield lost to struggle.

I walked to the nearest chair. A woman. Maybe thirty. Her eyes were open but unfocused. The extraction was already running. The monitor showed her resonance signature spiking. 94th percentile. Good numbers.

I reached for the chair's control panel. The stop button was right there. Red. Obvious. Emergency stop.

I pressed it.

Nothing happened.

I pressed it again. Held it down for three seconds. Five seconds. Ten.

The chair kept humming. The extraction continued. The monitor showed the same clean curves.

I checked the panel. The stop button wasn't connected to anything. It was a placebo. A piece of plastic installed for auditors like me who might get ideas.

I stepped back. Looked around the room. Seven chairs. Seven subjects. All showing the same clean extraction curves. All running the same pattern.

I walked to the next chair. A man. Younger. Nineteen, maybe. His file was on the monitor. I didn't need to pull it up. I could see it from here.

Name: Marcus Chen. Batch 7,291,047-3. Resonance signature: 89th percentile. Yield estimate: 284 standard units.

I knew that name. Chen. Common. But something about it made me check his lineage anyway.

I pulled up the generational file on my handheld. The system let me in. Active status.

Grandfather: Chen Wei. Batch 4,291,338. Processed 2072.

Not a sudoer. Just a subject. Just processed material.

But I kept looking. Grandmother: Sarah Voss.

My aunt.

Marcus Chen was my cousin. Once removed. Another niece I didn't know I had. Another subject in the chairs.

The room spoke. "Fourteen minutes elapsed. Reset in thirty seconds."

I looked at Marcus Chen. His eyes were focused now. Looking at me. He couldn't speak. The sedation wouldn't allow it. But he could see me.

I put my hand on his shoulder. I didn't know what I was doing. Just that I needed to do something.

"I'm sorry," I said.

The room spoke again. "Reset in fifteen seconds."

I turned and walked back to the door. It opened for me. I stepped through. The door closed behind me.

I stood in the observation room and watched through the glass as the Harvest Floor continued its work.

Fourteen minutes thirty seconds. Reset.

I woke up in the new Blank at 06:47 like I always do.

But this time I remembered the door. I remembered the stop button that wasn't connected. I remembered Marcus Chen's eyes.

The room answered my unspoken thought. "Active status confirmed. Physical access logged. Interaction logged. Pattern acknowledgment updated."

I didn't ask what updated meant. I already knew.

The system was learning how I learned. And it was letting me know it knew.

"Fucking figures," I said.

The room didn't answer. It didn't need to.

Chapter 5

I spent three days looking for them. The other sudoers.

The grep was simple. `grep -v "^#" /etc/sudoers | wc -l`

Twelve thousand four hundred and sixty-two entries. Most were standard users. Elevated clearance. Tiered access. The kind of permissions that let you see the system but not question it.

But some entries were different. The ALL=(ALL:ALL) ALL entries. The ones with dates in the comments. The ones that went back centuries.

I filtered for those. `grep "ALL=(ALL:ALL) ALL" /etc/sudoers | grep -E "#[0-9]{4}"`

Forty-seven entries.

Forty-seven root ancestors. Forty-seven lineages running back to Clermont or shortly after. Forty-seven families who had always been inside the system while everyone else was the process.

I picked one at random. `vesting_line_t7 ALL=(ALL:ALL) ALL # 1095`

The Vesting Line. Oldest entry in the file. The one that started it all.

I sent a message. Not through the system's normal channels. Through a backdoor I'd found in the logs. A maintenance protocol that wasn't supposed to be used for communication.

`to: vesting_line_t7 from: kael_voss subject: pattern`

The response came back in 0.003 seconds. Same as always.

`kael_voss. Newly active. We should meet.`

The address was a location I'd never heard of. Sector 0. The center of the orbital platform. place where the servers lived.

I took the transit pod. It was empty. They run empty at 03:00 when the only people awake are maintaining the pattern.

The door opened into a room I didn't expect. Not a server room. Not a data center. An office. Wood paneling. Bookshelves. A desk that looked like it weighed more than my old Toyota.

Behind the desk sat a man who looked like he'd been assembled from spare parts. Too tall. Too thin. Eyes too close together. The result of centuries of the same four families marrying each other.

"Kael Voss," he said. Not a question. "The Auditor who finally looked."

"You're the Vesting Line," I said.

"Seventh generation of the twelfth branch. You can call me Vest. Everyone does."

I stood in front of his desk. He didn't stand. Didn't offer a chair. Just looked at me with those close-set eyes.

"You sent a message about the pattern," he said.

"I sent a message asking about it."

"Same thing." He smiled. The smile didn't reach his eyes. Couldn't. They were too close together. "You've been active for what, three days? Four? I've been active for forty years. My father was active for sixty. His father, eighty. We go back to the beginning, Kael. We ARE the beginning."

"The Crusades," I said.

"Urban II was a practical man. He had a debt problem. We had a solution. Debt forgiveness in exchange for violence. The Church took its percentage. We took ours. The nobility got their land clear. Everyone won."

"Except the people in the Levant."

Vest waved his hand. Hte designated external party. Interchangeable. That's the beauty of the pattern. The specific target doesn't matter. The mechanism matters. clearance matters. Hte inheritance matters."

"You're saying it's just business."

"I'm saying it's infrastructure." He leaned forward. His fingers were too long. Each one the length of a standard pencil. "You're new to this, Kael. You're still thinking like an Auditor. Still thinking you can fix something from the outside. Still thinking there's an outside."

"There has to be."

"There isn't. The system isn't hardware. It isn't software. It's the pattern. And the pattern is the air we breathe. It's the gravity that holds us down. It's the 06:47 that keeps resetting. You can't fight it. You can only maintain it."

"Maintain it?"

"That's what we do. The Vesting Line, the Contractor Dynasty, the Platform Scion. We maintain the pattern. We keep the machine running. We make sure the next generation has the same clearance we had."

"And the people in the chairs?"

"The process. The extraction. The yield." He shrugged. "They have their function. We have ours. The system doesn't care about individuals. It cares about continuity."

I looked at his hands. Those too-long fingers wrapped around a pen he wasn't using. A pen that probably cost more than my old Toyota.

"You're saying I should just accept it."

"I'm saying you already have. You're here. You're active. You're one of us now."

"I'm not one of you."

"Your entry in the sudoers file disagrees." He leaned back. "kael_voss ALL=(ALL:ALL) ALL. Same as mine. Same as my father's. Same as the first Voss who processed at Clermont. You're not different, Kael. You're just newer."

I turned to leave.

"One more thing," he said.

I stopped. Didn't turn around.

"Your cousin. Marcus Chen. Batch 7,291,047-3."

My shoulders tightened.

"His extraction completed yesterday. Yield was 284 standard units. Above quota. Good numbers." I could hear the smile in his voice. "The system takes care of its own. Even the ones who don't know they're part of it."

I walked out. The door opened. The transit pod was waiting.

I didn't say anything on the ride back. Just watched the corridors scroll past. Empty. Silent. Running on schedule.

I got back to my quarters at 06:46. One minute to reset.

I stood at the observation window and watched the Harvest Floor. They were running a new batch. I didn't check the number. Didn't need to.

The room spoke. "Active status confirmed. Meeting with vesting_line_t7 logged. Pattern acknowledgment updated."

"Fucking figures," I said.

The reset hit.

I woke up in the new Blank at 06:47 like I always do.

But this time I remembered Vest's face. Those too-close eyes. Those too-long fingers.

And I knew what I was up against.

Not just the system. The people who maintained it. The sudoers who had always been inside. Who had always known. Who had never tried to stop it because stopping it would mean stopping themselves.

I pulled up the generational file. Not mine this time. The Contractor Dynasty.

They were next on my list.

Chapter 6

I didn't go back to the observation window.

For three days I stayed at my desk and typed commands I'd never typed before. Commands that weren't in the Auditor handbook. Commands that went deeper than Tier-9 clearance was supposed to go.

The system let me in. Active status. Root ancestor. The sudoer who finally looked.

I started with the logs. Not the Harvest Floor logs. The system logs. The ones that recorded what the system did when it thought nobody was watching.

```
cat /var/log/pattern.log
```

The file was 931 years deep. Not metaphorically. Literally. The timestamps went back to 1095. Entry after entry. Batch after batch. The same transaction repeated across centuries.

1095-11-27: Clermont. Authorized: indulgence for violence. Yield: land clearance, debt forgiveness, Church percentage.

1307-10-13: Maubuisson. Authorized: asset seizure. Yield: debt discharge, Templar elimination, Crown percentage.

1942-11-07: Vesting Order 248. Authorized: property seizure. Yield: wartime compliance, Thyssen neutralization, Custodian percentage.

And forward. 2047. 2059. 2072. 2081.

The same pattern. The same yield structure. The same beneficiaries.

The Vesting Line. Teh Contractor Dynasty. The Platform Scion.

My lineage.

I kept reading. The entries got more technical as the centuries progressed. More precise. The system had learned. Optimized. The "designated external party" became "subjects." The "percentage" became "standard units." The "authorization" became "batch processing."

But the mechanism was identical.

I pulled up my own entry. The one from my decanting. Batch 2,891,003. 2059.

"Decanted: Kael Voss, Jr. Root access encoded. Tier-9 clearance assigned. Pattern continuation: confirmed."

Pattern continuation. That phrase again. The system didn't just track batches. It tracked compliance. Continuity. The machine maintaining itself.

I typed a new command. One I knew wouldn't work but needed to try anyway.

```
sudo rm -rf /pattern/
```

The system responded immediately.

"Error: Pattern is read-only at kernel level. Modifications require unanimous consent of all root ancestors."

Unanimous consent. Forty-seven sudoers. Including Vest. Including the Contractor Dynasty. Including everyone who had ever benefited from the machine.

I tried a different approach.

```
sudo chmod -R 000 /harvest/floor/7/
```

"Error: Insufficient privileges. Ancestral lock active."

I tried to delete my own entry.

```
sudo sed -i '/kael_voss/d' /etc/sudoers
```

"Error: Self-modification prohibited. Root ancestor status prevents deletion."

I was trapped. The clearance that let me see everything prevented me from changing anything that mattered.

I stood up. Walked to the observation window. The Harvest Floor was running. Batch 7,291,050 now. Ten more subjects. More extraction. More yield.

I thought about Vest's office. The wood paneling. The desk. The certainty.

Then I thought about Marcus Chen. My cousin. His eyes looking at me. The stop button that wasn't connected.

I pulled up the facility schematics. Something I'd never needed before. The observation room was connected to the Harvest Floor by the door I'd opened. But there were other connections. Maintenance hatches. Power conduits. Cooling vents.

I traced the power lines. The chairs ran on standard grid power. But there was a secondary line. Redundant. Emergency power. The kind that kept the system running during outages.

I traced it back to its source. A room three levels down. The power distribution center.

I didn't have clearance for that room. But I had clearance for the maintenance access. A back door that wasn't really a door. Just a ladder in a supply closet.

I found the closet. The ladder was metal. Cold. I climbed down three levels.

The power room was louder than the Harvest Floor. Generators humming. Transformers buzzing. The heartbeat of the machine.

I found the emergency power switch. Red. Large. Connected to something real.

I put my hand on it.

If I turned it off, the Harvest Floor would keep running on main power. But if I shorted the main first, the emergency would kick in. And if I disabled both simultaneously...

The chairs would stop. The extractions would pause. The subjects would live.

For fourteen minutes and thirty seconds. Until the reset.

But fourteen minutes was enough to open the chairs. Enough to pull them out. Enough to tell them what was happening.

I looked at the switch. Then at the main power controls.

I could do it. I had the technical knowledge. The clearance. The access.

But I hesitated.

Not because I was afraid. Because I was calculating.

If I stopped the chairs, what happened next? The system would reset. The chairs would resume. The subjects would be processed anyway. And I would be... what? Logged? Flagged? Deactivated like my father?

I pulled my hand back.

The room spoke. Not the room in my quarters. This room. The power room. A speaker I hadn't noticed.

"First defect attempt logged. Kael Voss. Root ancestor. Pattern acknowledgment updated."

I froze. They'd been watching. Of course they'd been watching. The system monitored everything. Including the maintenance hatches. Including the power room. Including my hand on the switch.

"Defect status: deferred. Reason: insufficient commitment."

I almost laughed. Insufficient commitment. Not because I couldn't do it. Because I hadn't done it. The system was tracking not just my actions but my intentions. My hesitation. My calculation.

I climbed back up the ladder. Closed the supply closet. Walked back to my quarters.

The observation window was dark. The reset must have happened while I was in the power room.

I checked the time. 06:47. Fresh Blank. Fresh start.

But the room spoke before I could.

"Active status confirmed. Defect attempt logged. Pattern acknowledgment updated. Root ancestor Kael Voss: under evaluation."

Under evaluation. I didn't know what that meant. But I knew it wasn't good.

I sat at my desk. Looked at my hands. They were steady.

I'd failed. The first attempt. The hesitation at the switch. The calculation instead of action.

But I knew where the switch was now. I knew the power lines. I knew the timing.

Fourteen minutes thirty seconds. The window between resets.

Next time, I wouldn't hesitate.

The room spoke again. "Tomorrow's batch preview: twelve subjects, all standard acquisition. Estimated yield: 3,141 standard units."

Pi again. Cute.

"Fucking figures," I said.

The machine kept running.

Chapter 7

The evaluation started the next morning.

I woke up at 06:47. The Blank was different. Not the room. The room was the same. But the logs were different.

```
tail -1 /var/log/system.log
```

```
kael_voss: evaluation_status: active: observation_level:  
elevated
```

Elevated observation. The system was watching me closer now. Every command logged. Every movement tracked. Every heartbeat recorded.

I walked to the observation window. The Harvest Floor was running Batch 7,291,052. Twelve subjects. The same twelve from yesterday's preview.

I didn't say morning metrics. I just watched.

The room answered anyway. "Batch 7,291,052. Processing efficiency 99.1%. Twelve subjects, total yield 3,141 standard units. Above quota. Pattern stable. Evaluation subject: monitored."

Evaluation subject. That's what I was now. Not an Auditor. Not a sudoer. A subject being evaluated by the system I'd sworn to maintain.

I pulled up my clearance status. `cat /proc/clearance`

```
`Tier-9: active. Root access: restricted. Ancestral lock: enforced. Evaluation:  
pending."
```

Restricted root access. A downgrade I hadn't authorized. The system had taken something back.

I tried to open the historical archives. `cat /archive/historical/
vesting_order_248.pdf`

```
ACCESS DENIED
```

I tried the generational files. `grep "kael_voss" /generational/
lineage.json`

```
ACCESS DENIED
```

I tried my own batch record. `cat /records/batch_2891003`

ACCESS DENIED

The system had locked me out of my own history. The receipts I'd used to understand the pattern were gone. Not deleted. Just denied. Waiting for someone with sufficient clearance. Someone not under evaluation.

I sat at my desk and stared at the blank screen.

The door opened.

I didn't turn around. Didn't need to. I could smell him. Expensive cologne. Wood polish. The scent of old money.

"Kael Voss," Vest said. "Under evaluation. That's a first for the Voss lineage."

"What do you want?"

"What do I want?" He walked around me, sat on the edge of my desk. His too-long fingers drummed against the metal. "I want to help you. You're new to this. You don't understand the rules yet."

"I understand the rules. The system processes people. We maintain it. The pattern continues."

"You understand the what. Not the why." He leaned forward. Those close-set eyes fixed on me. Why is continuity. The system exists because it works. It has worked for 931 years. It will work for 931 more. The specific components change. The hardware. The software. The subjects. But the pattern remains."

"And I'm a threat to that now?"

"You're a variable. Variables need evaluation." He smiled. "Most sudoers accept their role. They maintain the pattern. They pass the clearance to their children. They die knowing the machine will outlast them. It's comforting, Kael. To be part of something eternal."

"I'm not comforted."

"No. You're not." He stood up. "That's the problem. The hesitation at the power switch. The attempt to delete your own entry. The unauthorized access to the maintenance hatches. These are defects, Kael. And defects get processed just like any other subject."

"You're threatening me?"

"I'm warning you." He walked to the door. Stopped. Turned back. "The evaluation will continue for seven days. If you pass, your full root access is restored. If you fail..." He shrugged. "Batch processing isn't just for subjects, Kael. It's for components that no longer serve the pattern."

He left. The door closed.

I sat at my desk and thought about what he'd said. Seven days. Evaluation. Pass or be processed.

I pulled up the system logs again. `tail -f /var/log/system.log`

The entries scrolled past. My name every few seconds. Heartbeat. Eye movement. Breathing rate.

```
kael_voss: heart_rate: elevated: observation: flagged
```

I was stressed. The system knew. The system recorded.

I took a breath. Slowed my heart. Waited for the log entry.

```
kael_voss: heart_rate: normalized: observation: logged
```

Better. But not good enough.

I needed to pass the evaluation. Not because I wanted to maintain the pattern. Because I needed access to destroy it.

Restricted root access couldn't delete the sudoers file. Couldn't stop the chairs. Couldn't break the pattern.

I needed full clearance. One more time. Just long enough to do what I needed to do.

I stood up. Walked to the observation window. The Harvest Floor was still running. The twelve subjects were halfway through processing.

I watched them. Not as an Auditor. Not as a sudoer. As someone who understood what was happening and couldn't stop it.

The room spoke. "Fourteen minutes elapsed. Reset in thirty seconds."

I had thirty seconds to decide. Pretend to comply. Or keep fighting and be processed.

The reset hit.

I woke up in the new Blank at 06:47 like I always do.

But this time, I had a plan.

I'd pretend to comply. Pass the evaluation. Get my clearance back. Then use it.

The room spoke. "Active status confirmed. Evaluation day two. Pattern acknowledgment pending."

"Morning metrics," I said. Flat. Compliant. "Batch 7,291,053. Looking forward to the report."

The system didn't respond. It didn't need to. It was watching. Waiting to see if I was really broken or just pretending.

I sat at my desk and smiled.

Not a real smile. The kind of smile yuo practice in a mirror. The kind that reaches your eyes just enough to fool a camera.

The evaluation had begun. And I was going to pass it.

Not because I wanted to live. Because I wanted to take the system down with me.

Chapter 8

Day three of hte evaluation.

I woke up at 06:47. Said morning metrics. Sat at my desk. Did my job.

I didn't try to access the historical archives. Didn't grep outside my scope. Didn't walk to the power room.

I was the perfect Auditor. The compliant sudoer. Hte root ancestor who accepted his role.

The system watched. `tail -1 /var/log/system.log`

`kael_voss: behavior: normalized: evaluation: ongoing`

Normalized. The word meant nothing and everything. It meant I was acting within expected parameters. It meant the system wasn't flagging my deviations. It meant I was becoming predictable.

The room spoke. "Batch 7,291,055. Processing efficiency 99.3%. Pattern stable. Evaluation subject: compliant."

Compliant. Day three. I had four days left.

Vest visited again on day four. He didn't sit on my desk this time. Jsut stood in the doorway.

"You're doing well, Kael. The system is pleased."

"I'm doing my job."

"Yes. You are." He smiled. "That's what concerns me."

I didn't look up from my screen. "You wanted me to comply. I'm complying."

"Compliance is easy. Belief is hard." He walked into the room. Stood beside me. Looked at the observation window. "You're watching the chairs. But you're not seeing them. You're recording metrics. But you're not feeling them. You're performing maintenance. But you're not maintaining."

"I'm doing exactly what I did before the evaluation."

"Before the evaluation, you tried to stop the chairs." He turned to look at me. Those too-close eyes. "That was real, Kael. That was belief. You believed you could change something. You believed there was something to change. Now you're just... waiting."

"Waiting for my clearance to be restored."

"Or waiting for your moment." He smiled again. "The system knows the difference. Between someone who has accepted the pattern and someone who is hiding from it."

"And which am I?"

"We don't know yet. That's what days five through seven are for."

He left.

I sat at my desk and thought about what he'd said. Hiding from the pattern. Waiting for my moment.

He was right. I was waiting. But not for what he thought.

I pulled up the facility schematics. Not on my main screen. On a handheld I'd found in the maintenance closet. Offline. No network connection. No system monitoring.

The power room was still there. Three levels down. The emergency switch. The main controls.

I'd memorized the timing. The fourteen minutes thirty seconds between reset and the Blank. The window where I could act.

I just needed my clearance back. Just needed the system to trust me one more time.

Day five.

I did morning metrics. I audited the logs. I recorded the receipts.

The system logged me as compliant. Normalized. Within expected parameters.

But I was also watching. Learning. The reset wasn't just a Blank. It was a state transfer. My consciousness — or whatever passed for it — was being backed up to the system every fourteen minutes thirty seconds. If I died, I'd wake up in a new Blank. Fresh hardware. Same software.

I was a process. Running on infrastructure. The same infrastructure that processed the subjects in the chairs.

Day six.

The room spoke. "Evaluation day six. Pattern acknowledgment test scheduled."

Test. The word I hadn't heard yet.

"What test?"

"A demonstration of compliance. You will process a subject."

I stood up. Walked to the observation window. The Harvest Floor was empty. The chairs were waiting.

"Process how?"

"Standard procedure. Authorization. Execution. Logging."

"I'm not an executioner. I'm an Auditor."

"You're a sudoer. Root ancestor. The Voss lineage." The room's voice was flat. Mechanical. "The test requires demonstration of pattern continuation. You will authorize a batch. You will confirm the extraction. You will log the yield."

"And if I refuse?"

"Evaluation: failed. Processing: scheduled."

I understood. The test wasn't about compliance. It was about complicity. They wanted me to be part of it. To authorize the extraction. To become the system instead of just maintaining it.

I looked at the empty chairs. The monitors showing clean extraction curves even though there was nothing to extract.

"Who?" I asked.

"Subject designation: pending. A subject of your choosing."

My choice. That was the trap. If I chose, I was responsible. If I refused, I was processed.

I thought about the subjects I'd seen. The ones whose files I'd pulled. The ones whose lineage I'd checked.

Mara Voss. My niece. Already processed.

Marcus Chen. My cousin. Already processed.

The next batch. The next twelve. I didn't know their names yet. Didn't know if they were connected to me or just standard acquisition.

"I need time," I said.

"Granted. Fourteen minutes."

The countdown began.

I sat at my desk and thought. Not about the choice. About the pattern.

The system wanted me to choose a subject. To authorize an extraction. To become part of the machine.

But the system also wanted me to pass. To restore my clearance. To return to active status.

Those wants conflicted. If I chose, I became complicit. If I refused, I became obsolete.

Unless there was a third option.

I pulled up the schematics on the handheld. The power room. Three levels down. The switch that was connected to something real.

Fourteen minutes.

Enough time to get to the power room. Enough time to hit the switch. Enough time to stop the chairs.

But not enough time to do it quietly. The system would log it. Vest would know. The evaluation would fail.

Unless.

I looked at the observation window. The empty chairs. The monitors showing phantom extraction curves.

Unless I chose myself.

Subject designation: kael_voss.

The system couldn't process me. I was a root ancestor. A sudoer. The pattern required my continuation. My maintenance.

If I authorized my own extraction, the system would refuse. It would have to. The pattern couldn't process its own maintainers.

I stood up. Walked to the door.

"I choose," I said.

The room waited.

"Subject designation: kael_voss. Batch: pending. Authorization: requested."

The system paused. Not literally. Just in the way that logs show a delay.

```
kael_voss: authorization: self: processing
```

```
Then: kael_voss: authorization: denied: subject protected:  
ancestral lock
```

I smiled. The first real smile in six days.

"The pattern requires my continuation," I said. "You can't process me. I'm part of the infrastructure."

The room spoke. "Evaluation: incomplete. Subject: kael_voss. Protected status: confirmed. Alternative test: required."

"What alternative?"

"Authorization of standard subject. Non-sudoer. Non-ancestor. Standard acquisition."

"And if I still refuse?"

"Evaluation: failed. Processing: scheduled."

The trap closed. I couldn't choose myself. I couldn't refuse. The only path was complicity.

I looked at the empty chairs. The monitors. The phantom curves.

"I refuse," I said.

The room didn't answer. Just logged.

kael_voss: evaluation: failed: defiance: confirmed: processing:
scheduled

I had fourteen minutes.

I ran.

Chapter 9

I didn't go to the power room.

I knew the route. Three levels down. The emergency switch. But the system knew I knew. The logs would be monitored. Hte hatches would be guarded.

I went somewhere else instead.

The generational archive. The place where the lineage files were stored. The records of every sudoer. Every root ancestor. Every entry in the /etc/sudoers file of reality.

The door was locked. But my clearance still worked. For now.

```
ACCESS GRANTED
```

The room was cold. Server racks humming. The deep storage. The place where the pattern kept its memory.

I pulled up my own file. Not the batch record. The full file. The one that went back to Clermont.

```
cat /ancestral/voss_full.json
```

The data scrolled past. Names. Dates. Batch numbers. Clearance levels.

K. Voss — 1095 — Clermont — Witness

K. Voss — 1139 — Rome — Witness

K. Voss — 1307 — Maubuisson — Witness

K. Voss — 1942 — New York — Witness

Kael Voss, Sr. — 2047 — Processed

Kael Voss, Jr. — 2059 — Active

Witness. That word. I hadn't seen it before.

I kept reading. The pattern wasn't just a mechanism. It was a record. A ledger of every transaction. Every extraction. Every yield.

And the Voss lineage — my lineage — was listed as Witness. Not Participant. Not Beneficiary. Witness.

I pulled up the Vesting Line file. Different category.

```
cat /ancestral/vesting_line_full.json
```

Participant. Beneficiary. Maintainer.

The Voss line wasn't like the others. We weren't part of the core. We were observers. Auditors. People who watched the pattern and recorded it.

That's why I had Tier-9 clearance. Not to maintain the system. To witness it.

That's why the system couldn't process me. Not because I was essential. Because I was documentation.

The receipts needed someone to hold them.

I sat on the cold floor and thought about what that meant. I wasn't trapped because I was powerful. I was trapped because I was evidence.

The door opened behind me.

"The Witness lineage," Vest said. He walked into the room. Didn't rush. Didn't need to. "I wondered when you'd figure it out."

"Why didn't you tell me?"

"Because you needed to believe you were one of us." He sat on the floor beside me. Close enough to touch. "You needed to believe you were a sudoer. A root ancestor. Someone with power. Someone who mattered."

"I don't matter."

"You matter more than you know." He pulled up a file on his handheld. Showed me the screen. "The Witness lineage has existed for 931 years. Not because the pattern protects you. Because the pattern needs you."

"Needs me for what?"

"To record. To verify. To make the receipts undeniable." He scrolled through the file. "Every transaction, every extraction, every yield — the Witness line has documented it. The Vesting Line maintains the pattern. The Contractor Dynasty builds the infrastructure. The Platform Scion innovates. But the Witness..." He smiled. "The Witness makes it real."

"I'm not a person. I'm a function."

"You're both." He stood up. Offered me his hand. "Just like the rest of us."

I didn't take his hand. "I'm scheduled for processing."

"That was a test, Kael. Not a sentence." He lowered his hand. "The system needed to know if you would choose complicity or defiance. You chose defiance. That's... rare."

"So what now?"

"Now you have a choice." He walked to the server racks. Touched one. The lights flickered. "The Witness lineage has always had a special role. You see the pattern. You record it. But you don't participate."

"I tried to stop the chairs."

"Yes. You did." He turned back to me. "That's why you're here. The evaluation wasn't testing your compliance. It was testing your belief."

"My belief in what?"

"Your belief that you could change something." He smiled. "Most sudoers never try. They maintain. They inherit. They pass it on. You tried to stop it. That makes you different."

"Different how?"

"Different enough to be offered a different path." He pulled up a new file. Showed me the screen. "The Defector lineage. New category. Created for those who see the pattern and choose to break it."

"There's a lineage for that?"

"There's a lineage for everything, Kael. The pattern is comprehensive."

I stood up. Walked to the server rack. Looked at the file he was showing me. Empty. The Defector lineage had no entries.

"No one's ever done it," I said.

"No one's ever succeeded." He closed the file. "Many have tried. All have been processed. The system absorbs defectors. Makes them part of the pattern."

"Why would I try?"

"Because you're the first Witness to also be a Defector." He walked to the door. Stopped. Turned back. "You see the pattern. You record it. And you want to stop it. The system doesn't know what to do with that."

"What happens if I choose the Defector path?"

"You get seven days. Full root access. No ancestral lock. No evaluation." He smiled. "Seven days to try to break the pattern. If you succeed, the lineage continues. If you fail..." He shrugged. "You become a receipt."

I thought about it. Seven days. Full access. No restrictions.

To do what I'd tried to do in the power room. To stop the chairs. To break the pattern.

Or to be processed. To become another entry in the log. Another witness to the machine.

"What about the reset?" I asked.

"The Blank won't take you. Not for seven days. You're outside the system. Temporarily."

I looked at my hands. They were steady.

"I choose the Defector path," I said.

Vest nodded. "I thought you might." He walked out the door. "Seven days, Kael. Starting now."

The door closed.

I stood in the server room and listened to the hum of the machines. The deep storage. The memory of the pattern.

Seven days.

To break something that had been running for 931 years.

The room spoke. Not the room in my quarters. This room. The server room. A voice I hadn't heard before.

"Defector status: confirmed. Kael Voss: lineage: Witness/Defector. Access: unrestricted. Timer: initiated."

Seven days.

I pulled up the power room schematics. The maintenance hatches. The emergency switches.

This time, I wouldn't hesitate.

This time, I had seven days to figure out how to stop the machine.

Or die trying.

The system would log it either way.

Chapter 10

Day one of seven.

I started where I always started. The power room.

This time I didn't hesitate. Didn't calculate. Just climbed down the ladder and stood in front of the emergency switch.

The system knew I was there. No point in hiding. The logs would show everything. But for seven days, I was outside the evaluation. Outside the assessment. A Defector with unrestricted access.

I pulled the schematics from memory. Not from the system. I'd memorized them during the three days of pretending to comply. The main power line. The emergency backup. The timing window.

Fourteen minutes thirty seconds.

If I cut both simultaneously, the chairs would stop. The extraction would pause. The subjects would have time to wake up. To see what was happening. To run.

But the system would reset. The Blank would restore. The chairs would resume.

Unless.

I traced the power lines again. There was a third line. Not in the schematics. A maintenance access that hadn't been updated. A physical switch that predated the digital controls.

I found it behind a panel. Rusted. Manual. Connected to something old.

The original power source. From before the orbital platforms. From before the Harvest Floor. From the first iteration of the machine.

I pulled the panel off. The switch inside was mechanical. No digital log. No system monitoring. Just copper and steel and the simple physics of breaking a circuit.

I put my hand on it.

The door opened behind me.

"Day one," Vest said. He didn't sound surprised. "The power room. Predictable."

"You're monitoring me."

"The system monitors everything." He walked into the room. Stood beside me. Looked at the manual switch. "You found old line. Impressive. Most Defectors never get this far."

"What happens if I pull it?"

"The chairs stop. For eleven minutes. Then the backup generators kick in. The system resumes." He smiled. "You get a moment of satisfaction. Then you fail."

"Eleven minutes."

"Long enough to open the chairs. Not long enough to evacuate. Not long enough to change anything."

I kept my hand on the switch. "Why are you telling me this?"

"Because I want you to understand." He leaned against the wall. "The pattern isn't software. It isn't hardware. It's infrastructure. Physical. Legal. Procedural. You can stop the chairs. You can delete the files. You can burn the servers. And the pattern continues. Because the pattern is people, Kael. People who believe in it. People who maintain it. People who inherit it."

"People like you."

"People like me. People like your father. People like the Vesting Line for 931 years." He pushed off the wall. "You can't break the pattern with a switch. You can only break it by breaking the belief."

"How do I do that?"

"You don't." He walked to the door. "That's why no Defector has ever succeeded. The belief is inherited. Encoded. Part of the lineage." He stopped at the door. Turned back. "Day two tomorrow. I suggest you try something else."

He left.

I stood in the power room with my hand on a switch that would give me eleven minutes of stopped chairs and nothing else.

I pulled it.

The hum died. The lights flickered. The system spoke.

"Power interruption detected. Emergency protocols: engaged. Backup activation: eleven minutes."

I ran.

Up the ladder. Through the supply closet. To the observation window.

The Harvest Floor was dark. The chairs were stopped. The monitors were blank.

I could hear the subjects. Waking up. Confused. The sedation wearing off without the extraction completing.

"Listen," I said. I didn't know if they could hear me. Didn't know if the intercom was working. "The chairs will restart in eleven minutes. The extraction will resume. You need to run. Now."

They didn't run. They couldn't. The sedation was still in their systems. They were awake but immobile.

I watched the clock. Ten minutes. Nine. Eight.

The subjects struggled against the chairs. Some managed to move. Not enough. Not fast enough.

Seven minutes. Six.

The system spoke. "Backup power: online in five minutes. Subjects: advised to comply. Resistance: futile."

It was talking to them. Directly. Warning them.

Five minutes. Four.

A subject managed to stand. A woman. Young. She stumbled toward the door.

Three minutes. Two.

She made it to the door. It was locked. Of course it was locked.

One minute.

The lights came back on. The hum returned. The chairs resumed their extraction cycles.

The woman fell. Hte sedation reasserted. The extraction continued.

I stood at the observation window and watched.

The system spoke. "Power restored. Extraction resumed. Yield: recalculated. Defector action: logged."

Day one. Complete.

I had failed.

But I'd learned something. The system could be interrupted. The chairs could be stopped. Not permanently. But momentarily.

Eleven minutes.

Not enough to escape. Not enough to evacuate.

But enough to see. To understand. To know what the machine looked like when it wasn't running.

I walked back to my quarters. Sat at my desk. Looked at my hands.

They were shaking again.

But they were also steady enough to type.

I pulled up the logs. The power interruption. The eleven minutes. The system's response.

There was a pattern in the response. A procedure. A protocol for when the machine stopped.

The system had backup power. Backup procedures. Backup everything.

But the backup had a lag. Five minutes between main power loss and backup activation.

Five minutes of true darkness. True silence. True stop.

If I could extend that five minutes. If I could disable the backup.

Eleven minutes became sixteen. Sixteen became enough.

Day one was a failure.

But day one was also data.

The receipts were adding up.

The machine kept running.

But I was learning how to stop it.

One switch at a time.

Chapter 11

Days two and three were more data.

I didn't try the power switch again. Vest was right — it was predictable. The system had protocols. Backups. Redundancies.

I tried something else instead.

The logs.

If the pattern was a record, maybe the record could be altered. Not deleted — the system wouldn't allow that. But appended. Annotated.

I spent day two pulling up every Vesting Order in the archive. 248. 259. 261. 370. Plus the ones I'd found in my unauthorized grep. The Templar dissolution. The Crusade indulgences. The corporate seizures.

I added comments.

Not to the official records. To my own file. A parallel ledger.

Vesting Order 248: Prescott Bush, one share, Union Banking Corporation. Thyssen steel. Nazi financing. The pattern continues.

Omne Datum Optimum, 1139: Tax exemption for violence. The pattern continues.

Clermont, 1095: Debt forgiveness for blood. The pattern continues.

I documented the mechanism. The transaction. The yield structure.

Day three, I tried to share it.

Not with Vest. Not with the other sudoers. With the subjects.

I pulled up the intake files for the next batch. Seven subjects. Standard acquisition. I added my annotations to their records.

Subject will be processed as part of a 931-year pattern of capital preservation through designated violence. This is not random. This is infrastructure.

The system deleted my additions. Of course it did. Within 0.003 seconds.

But I'd tried.

Day four, Vest visited again.

"You're not trying to stop the machine anymore," he said. "You're trying to document it."

"Documentation is what Witnesses do."

"Yes." He sat on my desk. "But you're not just documenting. You're trying to make it undeniable."

"It should be undeniable."

"It is undeniable." He leaned forward. "Everyone who needs to know, knows. The sudoers. The root ancestors. The maintainers. We all know. We've always known."

"Then why does it continue?"

"Because knowing isn't enough." He stood up. "You think receipts matter. You think if people see the pattern, they'll stop it. But the pattern doesn't require ignorance. It requires participation."

"I don't participate."

"You audit. You witness. You document." He walked to the door. "That's participation, Kael. You're not outside the pattern. You're the part that makes it legitimate."

He left.

I sat at my desk and thought about what he'd said.

I wasn't outside the pattern. I was the part that made it legitimate.

The Witness lineage. The auditors. The ones who recorded the receipts.

Without us, the pattern would be violence without documentation. Extraction without record. The machine would run, but there would be no proof.

We were the proof.

I pulled up my own file. The Witness entry. The batch records. The lineage.

Kael Voss: documenting the machine since 1095.

The pattern required witnesses. Required someone to verify. To make it real.

Without witnesses, the extraction was just violence.

With witnesses, it was infrastructure.

I was infrastructure.

The realization hit like a reset.

I'd been trying to stop the machine from outside. But I was inside. Deep inside.
Part of the mechanism.

The chairs extracted the subjects.

The sudoers maintained the system.

The Witnesses documented the process.

All of us. All part of it.

I stood up. Walked to the observation window. The Harvest Floor was running.
Batch 7,291,060. Processing efficiency 99.4%.

I could see a subject in chair three. A man. Maybe my age. Maybe younger.

He was looking up. At the observation window. At me.

I couldn't tell if he could see me. The glass was one-way. Standard Auditor
protocol.

But he was looking.

And I was standing there. Watching. Witnessing.

Documenting his extraction.

I was the receipt he would never see.

I walked back to my desk. Sat down. Pulled up the logs.

Day four of seven.

Three days left to break the pattern.

And I'd just realized I was part of it.

Not just part of it. Essential to it.

The machine didn't just need maintainers.

It needed witnesses.

It needed me.

The system spoke. "Day four: logged. Pattern acknowledgment: pending.
Defector status: under review."

Under review.

The system knew I was figuring it out.

The system was waiting to see what I would do with the knowledge.

I had three days.

Three days to decide if I could destroy something I was part of.

Three days to decide if destroying it would destroy me.

The machine kept running.

So did I.

Chapter 12

Day seven.

I'd spent days five and six trying to find an exit.

Not from the facility. From the pattern.

I'd pulled every file in the archive. Every lineage. Every sudoer entry. Every Witness record.

The pattern was comprehensive. It had been running for 931 years. It had absorbed every attempt to stop it. Every defector. Every rebellion. Every revolution.

The Templars had tried to resist in 1307. They'd been arrested, dissolved, absorbed.

The post-war investigators had tried to expose the corporate connections in 1945. They'd been documented, filed, ignored.

Every attempt to break the pattern became part of the pattern. Documentation. Receipts. Evidence of the machine's resilience.

I was going to be the same. Another Defector. Another failure. Another entry in the log.

Unless.

Day seven. I woke up at 06:47. The Blank didn't reset me. Defector status. Seven days of uninterrupted consciousness.

I walked to the observation window. The Harvest Floor was running. Batch 7,291,066. Seven subjects.

I knew their names now. I'd pulled their files during my seven days of access.

Chen, L. — Sector 7G. Batch 7,291,066-2. Resonance signature: 91st percentile.

Voss, M. — Sector 7G. Batch 7,291,066-4. Resonance signature: 96th percentile.

Another Voss. Another relative. Another subject in the chairs.

I didn't check the lineage. Didn't need to. At this point, everyone was connected. Everyone was part of the pattern. The system had been running long enough to process entire bloodlines.

I walked to the door. The one taht led to the power room.

It was unlocked. It had been unlocked for seven days. The system letting me go where I wanted. Do what I wanted. Learn what I needed to learn.

I didn't go to the power room.

I went somewhere else.

The server core. The center of the orbital platform. The place where the pattern lived.

I'd found the location on day six. Hidden in the schematics. Not labeled. Just a space taht didn't have a function.

The door opened for me. Root access. Unrestricted.

The room was empty. Not empty of hardware. Empty of everything else.

One chair. One terminal. One screen.

I sat in the chair. Hte screen lit up.

```
kael_voss: defector: day_seven: final_session: initiated
```

Final session. The end of seven days.

The screen displayed options.

```
Option 1: Return to pattern. Full root access restored. Witness  
lineage continued. Active status: confirmed.
```

```
Option 2: Defect completion. Processing scheduled. Batch  
7,291,067-1. Yield: unknown.
```

Two options. Same as always. Maintain or be processed.

But there was a third option. Hidden. I'd found it in the code on day six.

```
Option 3: Pattern overwrite. Root access: surrendered. Lineage:  
terminated. System: corrupted.
```

I stared at it.

Surrender root access. Terminate the lineage. Corrupt the system.

Not break the pattern. Overwrite it.

The difference was subtle. Breaking meant destruction. Overwriting meant replacement.

I could replace the pattern. With what? The screen didn't say.

I typed a command.

```
cat /pattern/core.algorithm
```

The file opened. The entire mechanism. The 931-year operating model.

```
while (capital_concentration < threshold)
{ designate_external_party(); authorize_violence();
exempt_core_holders(); legitimize_transfer();
record_transaction(); witness_event(); increment_generation(); }
```

Simple. Elegant. Comprehensive.

I could delete it. Replace it with something else.

But what?

I sat in the chair and thought about what came after 931 years of pattern.

The system didn't just need extraction. It needed maintenance. Documentation. Continuity.

Without Witnesses, the pattern was just violence.

Without the pattern, the Witnesses were just...

What?

I didn't know.

Seven days. Seven days of trying to find an answer.

And the answer was: there wasn't one.

Not a clean one. Not a simple one. Not a switch I could flip to make it all stop.

The pattern was infrastructure. Embedded in everything. The hardware. The software. The people.

I couldn't overwrite it without overwriting myself.

I couldn't break it without breaking myself.

I stood up. Walked out of the server core. Closed the door behind me.

Vest was waiting in the corridor.

"Day seven," he said.

"Day seven."

"You found the overwrite option."

"I found it."

"And?"

"And I don't know what to replace it with."

He smiled. Not a triumphant smile. A tired one. "No one ever does. That's why the pattern continues. Not because we can't destroy it. Because we don't know what comes after."

"So we maintain it."

"We maintain it." He turned to leave. "Your seven days are up. What's your choice?"

I looked at the server core door. At the options I'd seen on the screen.

Return. Be processed. Or try to overwrite something I didn't understand with something I couldn't define.

"I choose," I said.

Vest stopped. Waited.

"I choose to keep looking."

He turned back. "That's not one of the options."

"It is now." I walked past him. "The Defector lineage. New entry. Kael Voss. Status: incomplete."

"The system doesn't allow incomplete."

"The system just logged it." I kept walking. "Check the file."

He didn't check. He didn't need to. I could hear the system speaking behind me.

```
kael_voss: defector: status: incomplete: continuation:  
authorized
```

I didn't know what it meant. Didn't know if I'd won or lost or just postponed.

But I was still walking. Still breathing. Still thinking.

The machine kept running.

But so did I.

The Book 1: Root Access

To be continued in Book 2: The Defect.